

DIVINELY UNREAL



GABRIELA RIVERA

Chapter 1

A crowd hooted in unison, all amassed before the town's Center. Jeremy was dashing straight at the event as if he would complete a marathon, frantically jostling across the bystanders. That day was a spectacular day, just like any other day when these anxious-felt trips took place. As an expedition group of his prominent village was selected for this devotion, their governor, Sarah Markwand, ushered the members down the wooden flight of stairs. Those wide stairs were located at the border of the island, where only survivors, curious people, and the dead have trespassed. His fellow relatives made a way for these fierce and brave people to advance. They were saying their goodbyes as if, hopefully, it wasn't their last one. And faintly, a band of musicians played salsa and traditional music in the background, with the sun spectating them above its beam.

Once Jeremy managed to regretfully crash with one of the member's back, they indignantly turned to face him. Her eyes were as glazed and as sculptured as a hazelnut, with the smoothest taint in her skin. A few wrinkles were present because of her old age, but rather unnoticeable; her beauty sustained these standards.

"Jeremy...", she plainly dictated. The flimsy boy rapidly perched up and embraced the woman, a tight clench around her waist.

"Come back home safe, mom! If you do that, the mission would be a success. If not, then there's no point in going!" He cried.

The mother huffed a solemn smile and removed her son's wrists, intertwining his hands with her fingers.

“Take good care of the village, and then I’ll have nothing to fret over. You have a lot of responsibilities and things to look out for to keep in mind, Jeremy. So in the meantime, don’t worry much about me.”

A whistle from Sarah emitted from behind, alarming the two that it was now, truly, time to depart. The mother understood this implicity and the heading march, so she gave her last endearing look and turned. Jeremy clung onto her hand until they sensed no more of his mother’s presence, consolance, and support, while all he did was watch before her farewell. He stood there while everyone else cheered with energy and excitement, a predominant feeling of anguish weathering his interior. He couldn’t do anything but watch. He couldn’t do anything but accept the inability to express his opposition and express the desire to absolutely stop the committee.

And as time slowed down to capture these very moments, a bizarre item dropped from his mother’s sling bag. It rolled over until stopping at the blades of grass, almost at the brink of falling off the platform. Certain that everyone in the field of vision could see it, Jeremy mustered the courage to fetch for that item. He didn’t mind the audience since their attention wasn’t directed to him. On his hand, he felt a cold metallic sensation, and gave a superficial inspection of the sphere before glancing back at the edge of the world.

The governor did not accompany the rest as they headed to the never-ending route. She remained there in case of any malicious deed, staring headlong into the abyss. Jeremy’s mother and the “Scout of the Edge” were going to traverse these lands— if they could even be called lands— in order to obtain food, water, provisions, building materials, and any other luxuries that would be welcomed. They acknowledge the fact that there are other universes, other entities living there, beyond their capabilities to understand. Farther away from this island, with much more advanced and developed technology. Well, that is what Jeremy’s been shared in school.

Jeremy then gazed, on a regular basis, at the strange structure of the land. It was arid, as if the dried soil was peeling off, with cracks rooting from one place to another. There was no body of water present, not even a lake, a river, or those rare puddles that are miraculously formed by the rain. He sometimes succumbs to the melancholic thought that a phenomenon that is so-called the *Ocean* exists. At least somewhere and anywhere else that is not that vacant.

It was like a desert, he compared. Because according to the books and the lectures he received in school, the theoretical history describes it as a place covered by sand and nothing else. It was data accumulated from predecessors and the scientists. But he's concluded that almost half of the information is biased, and congested with plain speculations instead of facts. There is no logical rationale as to explain why the surface of his dear island is nothing but a withered layer of the Earth.

Another inexplicable feature that not even the experts could put into words, was the wide gap in the soil, next to the island. It was rectangular in shape, and the depth of the hole seemed like it could lead to hours and hours to finally reach the bottom. The bottom that would most likely be classified as the core of the Earth. Some theorists assume that gods or mythological creatures have carved this mark on the planet or that it is geographically formed this way. But despite that, that little scary inconvenience has been ironically placed as their *Pacific Deal*. Whenever a murder happens, witnesses come by first. However, if no suspects can be found whatsoever, all of the people in the village are instructed to march to the fountain, which is in the middle of the island (Center), and they will all be examined. Once the criminal is discovered and is surely guilty, they are dumped in the hole, which is usually closed with enormous wooden planks to prevent innocent people from getting pushed. This suggests a lot of mistakes and false accusations, but it was a harsh reality that Jeremy could not interfere with.

His mother was fortunately one of the most significant figures in that village, apart from being a social space where ideas easily proliferated. She was, after all, an anthropologist and was strongly required to volunteer in that mission since Jeremy has constrained her from not leaving for long. He has no father, and that is because, in one of the expeditions from many years ago, he left and never returned.

“Probably to look for a better life,” Jeremy slurred beneath his breath as the ugly memory spawned in his mind, an obstinate feeling of hatred fuming in. He scratched his neck in nervousness, the rowdy mass emerging from behind to observe the silhouettes shrink smaller and smaller. And there it went. His mother, in an instant, joined *The Other Side of the World* after surpassing the horizon.

Jeremy found his way to escape the whole situation, now retaining a firm grip on the item. As he walked up the hill on the sidewalks, he looked in clearer detail the whole specialty of the sphere. It wasn't just like any other spheres he's seen. This one was evidently made with extravagant material, value, and had an abnormal function. He couldn't figure the purpose of it.

It was an ancient armillary sphere with an eye in the middle. Wherever he'd move his hand, it followed him like some sort of creepy spy. The structure, as well, motioned according to the direction, smoothly. But as much as it unnerved him, he didn't want to let go of it.

The streets were not as occupied as normal days. It was a narrow sidewalk since fuel-generated engines were not the island's domain of transportation. Instead, many used scooters, skateboards, and rollerblades. Actually—the rollerblades weren't done yet as Jeremy's friend, Ennard, was still perfecting their design. The type of currency that existed was trading, and mainly farmers, policemen, doctors, architects, engineers, and low-classified scientists received a level of favoritism from the government. After all, they had a very promising and

significant role. Even so, an education more elevated than high school was not available considering the large population density and the little space to construct. The majority were just “naturally gifted” or accompanied the “Scout of the Edge” back to the homeland. They were the source of knowledge and the future of the people.

But like the rest of the villagers and average citizens, everyone had equal status. Or at least that is what they say. The poor live equally and the rich live absolutely. The island collaborates altogether to support the community in its bestest way, and deter any act of unfairness. Though that did not mean there was all good in that limited land. Even having little water supply and no landscape of water was deemed substantial when it comes to survival.

“H-Hey?! Those are my supplies!” Jeremy shouted, half unsure at the sight of his building supplies being looted by three passengers. They turned their heads accordingly, a nonchalant expression reigning over.

“Yours? Aren’t we supposed to be a generous community that helps those in need? We need this to fix our shack, which is in ruins!” One of the older girls said. “Don’t be greedy!”

“B-but you’re not even asking for it!” He replied, frustrated that, regardless of his emotions, he couldn’t resort to any kind of fight. What they were doing was practically theft.

“Shut up, Jeremiah!” The petite one next to the older girl kicked Jeremy’s leg, which caused him to defenselessly caress it. He hunched his shoulders in a shameful gut, a hand sustaining the armillary while the siblings hurried to the opposite side. Regardless, he cursed and slightly limped away.

Arriving home, he shut the door with an awful silence and placed the finding on the desk table. The first-floor of the house was met by a sensation of solitude and cavernous atmosphere. It was like a cottage with a vintage-like design. Then, he thought about his mother, how she was

probably three hundred meters away from the land already. All he was brooding about concerned his mother's state, since she's never distanced herself so expansively.

Wishing for a distraction, he opened the window frame and climbed over it. Hopping to the ladders, up on the roof a couple of friends awaited to greet him.

"Hey, bud! How was the goodbye?" A hefty girl lit up the second-floor room with her vibrant energy. Known as Alvy, she had a frisky ponytail and was suited up with shorts. The majority of the group was inclined against a comfy pouch of cotton bags that work as cushions. Some were scooping vegetable seeds into their corresponding packs.

Jeremiah sighed. "Not necessarily good." Colin frowned upon this statement. He had a shaved head and was larger in both age and height.

"What do you mean? How could it have gotten bad?" He directly questioned.

Jeremy rearranged his words, troubled in his mind with needless thoughts but just plain exaggerations. "Well, I'm going to miss my mom and— I'm not even going to ask but, none of you have noticed that a few of my materials were stolen by the Patrichia siblings again."

Alvina opened her mouth in surprise. She gripped her hands to form punches in battle. "They were sly, yet again!"

"It doesn't matter, though," he briefly paused for another sigh. "I have Ennard with me to help me fill in the missing parts, don't I?"

The guy named Ennard shot a look up at the mentioning of their name, an irritated transparency over his face. "If it's to redo that damn toy, I'm resigning."

Jeremy cringed as if his plans were easily read. "Not... entirely." He muttered to not let chances go in vain, no matter the lies. "Come on! This time, I'll make it grandiose! The best!"

The most beloved and bade product in our Village of Kamui Seigen!” He imagined enthusiastically. Ennard was unfazed.

“Of course, of course. Everyone in Archia wants your boat with four wheels to roam the streets when they could, instead, use mine, which holds more passengers than that twig.”

Jeremy brooded in low hopes, feeling like his ideas were shushed. Ennard noticed this and denied, in his interior, that sense of guilt, but it wins over him.

“Alright... fine... Maybe we’ll start a new project tomorrow.” Ennard switched back to his doing, unknotting a handful of yarn. Jeremy takes a note of this compromise and triumphs internally.

“Where is Niche?” He then asks publicly. Niche is one of his aspiring idols. She’s the embodiment of everything Jeremy lacks, and he assumed that is why he looks forward to understanding her combat and flexibility abilities. Moreover, both of their fathers abandoned them as a child, so there is a stronger bond between their level of understanding. Alvina and Colin glanced at each other in doubt.

“We don’t know. We haven’t seen her.” Colin nodded at Alvina’s saying.

Jeremy takes a deep thought. “I just want all of us to be together at tonight's gathering. Since the Christmas event will take place soon... and I-”

“Talking about that...” Ennard muttered, perching up. “I’ll need to head out before night to help out the musicians. Colin, come with me to set up the decorations.” Their friend Colin respectively stood up, without a bother, and accompanied them down the trail of stairs.

Jeremy wordlessly turned to Alvina and crouched to finish off the remaining seeds out of the bag. It was a silent exchange, at first.

“Watermelon seeds,” she softly uttered.

Jeremy frowned back, confused. “W-what?”

“These are watermelon seeds. They grow into big green-striped coconuts, but, instead, they have juicy pink fruits inside,” she commented, holding up in-between her fingers the coffee-coloured seed. A wide smile plastered on her face. “Our farmer Mr. Larry said they taste just like water, with flavor.”

In Jeremy’s mind, he was intrigued, as well, by the eccentric taste that almost no one in the village has experienced at least once in their lives. Like the rest of the people, he normally consumes grains, water, and chicken, but nothing as special as any kind of fruit.

Once packing up the bags, Jeremy availed Alvina with the heavy units, and directed to the rear of the overpopulated area. The night sky was already pouring in, and the clouds lost their density within the cold air. Both of them eventually arrived at their destination, before a closed door of a house. Alvina and Jeremy simultaneously dropped their bags down and she knocked on the surface of the door with her fist. The other side prolonged a longer silence than the crickets surrounding them. Following a few thudding noises, someone made their way towards them. Soon it opened at ease, presenting an old man upon the entrance.

“What is it, young fellows, that you want at this strike of the hour?” He heaved with an inquisitive tone.

“Here are the watermelon seeds, pal! Just as you asked!” Alvina advised, dragging the bags in front, stationing them before the man. “This costs a fortune!”

The man squinted his eyes and she could finally see the light in them. “Ohh, you’re one of my sellers!” His face completely inverted to a cheerful one. “Bring ‘em o’er here! Bring ‘em!” He beckoned them.

“Yes, yes,” Alvina stated in evident anxiety and hurry, lifting the bags to the man’s interior home. If Jeremy’s assumption was correct, Alvina was competing against someone else. Like always. To compete against who was the fastest deliverer. Jeremy rotated slowly but suspensefully, and, coincidentally discerned emerging figures dashing towards him in the distance.

“They’re coming! They’re coming!” He shouted for Alvina. The girl exited the home with a fun expression, and disrespectfully shut the door without a thought. The group was already nearing and they had mounted their bags over their backs like madmen.

“That— we lost again!” One of the main runners yelled. They hurled their bags over another’s burden and darted even faster to them. Alvina and Jeremy gripped each other and made a run for it, to their right side.

“Alvy! Jeremy!” A voice called them from above. They glanced up and noticed Niche on top of a rooftop, like always. She had a headband with a skull clip on her hair. She tossed her axe with her single arm, straddled with a steady rope. The two flinched, frightened that it might have injured them, but immediately Alvy grappled it. Niche lifted her up by exerting force, and meanwhile that, Jeremy continued to pace down the streets. On the turn of a corner, he saw the light behind him flicker, suggesting that they were close. But unlike Niche, he was mindless about how to climb buildings; all he wanted to do was flee.

One of the runners had caught up to Jeremy and hauled him by the collar of the shirt. He shrieked, but before any violence occurred, an egg smashed their face, blinding their vision. Jeremy chuckled to himself before escaping like a coward before the rest cornered him.

Jeremy heard Alvina’s cackles on top of the rooftops, and urged him to look up again. He didn’t realize it either, but she had a plastic bag clipped to her belt. She then hopped down

dramatically on the ground as if her legs were made of steel. This allowed Niche to let loose of the axe, this time, for Jeremy to grab on. And he instructively did.

Now that he was on the same platform, he could see everything from above but with a slight fear of heights. They were fighting over the plastic bag that Alvina had on her waist; probably an item that they mutually treasured. Niche handed Jeremy the eggs for attack, and he pridefully held it.

The fight had ceased in an instant when Alvina had called the white, feisty cats over. They all swarmed down the streets in direction to the group, which granted her the time to climb up from the windows. The moment she joined the other two she had a relieved and relished face, as if she had finished off a strenuous workload.

“Man, that was something!” She laughed, removing the shell of the egg from her shoulder.

“Why did they want the bag so much? What’s inside of it?” Jeremy asked. Alvina noted that and opened the interior to exhibit a conduit measuring tape, potatoes, apples, and a match box.

Jeremy stared in both confusion and amazement. They were very essential items in this island, like potatoes and a match box, but having a hazard item without a license was forbidden, according to the government.

“If anyone finds out that you obtained a match box, you’ll be condemned,” Niche bluntly warns. Alvina nodded as if she was aware of the consequences, but did not mind them.

“I know that none of you will snitch. We hate how this government operates, so I don’t care if anything happens to me. But I won’t get caught because I still need to take care of my sisters.”

“What about that measuring tape?” Jeremy mentioned, intrigued. Alvina grabbed it and passed it to him. His face was absolutely stunned when he read the “3,000 feet” mark.

“Including that... It’s to measure the depth of the hole next to our island. How can we live in peace without knowing what in the world does that hole measure?”

“But haven’t the scientists measured it already?” Niche added.

“Yes, but they don’t want to tell us. What if it’s infinite that they’re too scared to share it to the public? What if it’s actually so shallow that people could just drop in?”

“Then what are you going to do with the information?” Jeremy asked, worriedly.

“Depending on the results, I’ll get Ennard to help me dive into it, or make the decision to leave this place.”

Jeremy returned to his house alongside Niche. Alvina had marched to check on her siblings. As the couple arrived, Jeremy was embraced by a chilling melancholic breeze. He wanted to join the Christmas event, but since the last two years he almost blazed up the place, he has been ousted ever since. Niche noticed the lagging pace, and briefly stopped in a sympathetic manner.

“Don’t let it trouble you. I’ll stay with you for the rest of the night,” she blankly said, inducing Jeremy to get flustered. Niche advanced and yanked the ax over the hanging pole. She was assured to attach it and dropped herself down, never failing to scare Jeremy. The pull and fall, due to the force, swung her up to the balcony. And she made it safely, while Jeremy took the ladders without a flint of confidence.

As the noise of the night soothed any disturbance, two friends lounged down in Jeremy’s room, a collection and innovative room. He was ashamed to not have cleaned up the place, but

he was too immersed in the construction of the boat, which he was fixing again because of the thieves' misplacement.

Niche was refurbishing her cane, which was more like a weapon, cleaning the rusty edges of the ax and replacing the rope.

"Do you know why Ennard has been more sensitive lately?" Niche inquired, sparking a conversation. Jeremy hummed as if he knew the answer by heart, not averting his attention.

"Ennard wants to show his ideas and creations to the villagers, but no one is interested in it. Not even the government. They think it's a waste of time when they should all just focus on survival and priorities."

Niche scoffed. "It's ironic how they hire musicians for these kinds of events, but are never open to testing out his art. It's a type of entertainment, after all."

"It is," Jeremy said. "But it's infuriating how we can't do anything about it. We can't rebel, because it's considered a crime. We can't advocate those opinions, because it's a crime."

"We can," she opposed. "It's just that we haven't found a way how to."

Niche stood up from Jeremy's bed and headed to the window aside, glancing through it.

"I have my own passions as well. People have assumed that I'm weak because I was born with a limb deficiency. I've proved them wrong after so many years of survival, but it's not enough. I know that I have to aim higher, and to do that, I'll surpass Alvina's status." A prideful tone filled in Niche's declaration. Jeremy listened, admiring her determination.

"But... you don't need other people's validation for that. You're already amazing!" Niche was surprised to hear that. She turned to face her own reflection.

"You're right. I only need my good friends."

Jeremy gulped happily, with a new thought that had visited him earlier.

“I’ll come back,” he said before exiting the room.

Jeremy examined his own house as if he were observing it for the first time, and remembered where he placed the strange armillary. It laid on his desk, where he quickly paced towards it. He wanted to give it as a present to Niche.

Although, grabbing it felt more bizarre than before, since he felt a mystical strength from just possessing it. He knew something felt odd in his home, especially in the main room. The eye located in the middle of the item was no longer following Jeremy, but outside, at the frame of his window. Jeremy noticed this and, terrified, shot to look at the same window, where the moonlight shone. He opened it with the armillary in hand, massive jitters conquering him. But curiosity was leading his will. For a second, the moonlight supernaturally aligned with the item’s core, an inexplicable nerve-wrenching impulse daunting Jeremy. He panted in fear and recoiled back, an luminous light beginning to flash before his eyes. And before he even processed his sense of reality and environment, the world shifted before him, and he disappeared on a whim.

There was no more of him in the primary version of the Earth. Jeremy had defeated all laws of physics, science, and reasoning, thanks to that abnormal energy stored in such an item.

Colin finished lifting the string clustered with jolly decorations, anchoring it to the wooden pole. The Center of the village was abundant with enjoyment and happiness, with food being the only source missing. People began to form crowds to admire the musicians. Ennard scoffed angrily at that, accompanying Colin after his labor.

“You shouldn’t have fixed their porch,” he said as if he were accounted for a wanton deed. Colin turned to where his friend referred to, and frowned upon that statement.

“But isn’t it my job? I’m just doing what my dad would have told me to do.”

Ennard rolled his eyes. “Helping those people?”

The people who were at the verge of attacking Niche, Alvina, and Jeremy, were arriving after receiving numerous scratches from the cats. They were Alexander, Terry, and Timothy, little rascals who despised seeing anyone succeed in a way that frustrated them. It was a personal and selfish reason, but they had nothing but Little Immature Kid syndrome excusing their antics. Moreover, Terry was the governor's son.

"Jeremy won't come this time because of what happened last year, right?" Colin asked to confirm.

"Yeah, that idiot... how could he have even caught the stage on fire?" The other laughed at the memory.

Niche suddenly appeared without Jeremy by her side. She had an agitated expression, imploring a consolation for her problem.

"Have any of you seen Jeremy?!"

Ennard, a little suspicious, affirmed, "No, we haven't. Why?"

"Because he's disappeared! He's nowhere on the island!"

Ennard and Colin were shocked in unison, their taunting hearts amplifying in volume. Their breaths grew intense as they, to a full extent, believed what Niche said. After all, Niche and Jeremy, when they were together, would never leave one's side unless they acknowledged it.

After a prolonged look, the three diverged from the event, and sprinted out in apprehension, equally purposed to seek out for their friend.

Chapter 2

Through a groggy remembrance, Jeremy urged his body to rouse up from the ground. Like normal, he progressed his surroundings in his head. Everything felt strangely normal. Had he been deep asleep in a dream? A few seconds ago he was immersed in a surreal experience, too surreal he couldn't even consider it a product of imagination. His distinction of reality and fiction was damaged.

Surely it must have been a headache, he reasoned as he stood up from the floorboard. Jeremy roamed the place as if he were a zombie dragging the heel of his foot. But the moment that he pushed the door open to his room, Niche wasn't there, as he had anticipated.

"She left...?" He muttered to himself in low spirits. A little sense of defeat enveloping his soul. Out of the sudden, a tumultuous bellow crept out the life of Jeremy; they started to fade in louder next to the exterior of his house. Jeremy immediately barged the door open to find himself more confused than ever.

All the people of the village strode upward to the pathway that leads to the rear of the island like soldiers. Everyone— every single person carried a torch in their hands, fulminating the smoke up in the contaminated night sky. They were, according to his level of understanding, heading towards the hole, where the *Pacific Deal* took place. The *Pacific Deal* was a trial, a judgment, and a process of punishing accused people for their crimes or unacceptable behavior by dunking them in the abyssal hole. This term was coined to name their executions, while the hole itself never acquired a proper label.

Jeremy advanced, blending in the crowd, with shivers of stress tormenting him. He was afraid to ask, afraid to know, and even afraid to figure out the logic behind this trial— which was organized on the same day of the Christmas event.

“E-Excuse me,” he tugged someone’s shirt close to him. She turned behind fiercely. “Who’s guilty?”

“Jeremiah, what are you doing here? You must be at the front already!” She admonished as they continued to move as instructed. Jeremy’s impatience fueled up.

“Why do I need to be at the front?” They didn’t respond so he gulped and accepted the exchange. Jeremy followed the people without a clue that supported his participation. Mildly intrigued, he examined the parade and saw a black cat climbing the rooftops. This distracted him for long, since there are usually no dark-coloured domestic animals on the island.

And at last, before he knew it, Jeremy was across the border of the execution. Before the peak of land where, the apparent silhouettes of Alvina and Ennard, knelt upon. Their faces were clouded with anguish and lament, a word of silence being recorded as their last words. Jeremiah jostled against the flood of people, and noticed himself walking up to the front. But it wasn’t him. It was another copy, another version of himself with a different vestiment. Although, all he knew was that they looked like nothing but an unfamiliar form.

Jeremy wanted to revolt against his people because their dear friends were labeled as cruel criminals. Whatever the reason, he knew that if any regulation was broken, it was done by the heart and not from evil intentions. He wanted to scream at Alvina and Ennard to get up from the grass and start running, but they were tied up by ropes around their chest.

But the next thing that the fake Jeremiah did caused Jeremy’s mouth to drop.

Using his feet, he pushed the two friends off the border, deliberately falling to their deaths. There was no emotion of remorse or guilt in his face. Absolutely nothing.

“Ennard!” Jeremy shouted at the top of his lungs, because there was enough air in him to expel in despair. He detached himself from the crowd and all fear ceased. There was only pain subduing his system. No awareness, no alarm of danger. Jeremy dropped down to the edge and helplessly witnessed Alvina and Ennard fall like disposable trash into the whelming darkness. His tears formed like sprouting flowers, weeping devastatingly that such a thing had happened to his significant ones. The spectators, once realizing that there were two Jeremiahs, all made a sound of disbelief, backing away.

“Hey! Why do you look familiar...?” The fake Jeremiah seethed, stomping towards the impostor.

At that point, Jeremy didn’t know what was happening anymore. How could the night switch from pleasant to gloomy, to a commonplace dream to an unavoidable nightmare? Jeremy’s heart felt like it was at stake, and now that he had lost the most important people in his life, the reason to live was absolutely discarded away.

“You’re-” Jeremy glanced up in fright, making eye-contact with his fated enemy. At himself. But once they shared a mutual glance, an empowering heavy headache pummeled in. Both of them grunted at that painful pulse, and due to this, Jeremy cowered away. The conglomerate crowd gasped as they instinctively dispersed at the impostor’s direction to escape. He limped as he was undermined by an endowing sense of perplexity and loss of control. A firm hold on his sole salvation: the armillary.

The second Jeremiah howled in evident fury.

“What are you all doing?! Catch that guy!”

Soon Jeremy was persecuted by dozens of people, and he ran for his life more than ever. His main objective was to find a solution to this predicament. He had figured that the armillary had to do with this supernatural phenomenon, and so he gripped it tightly.

The moment he arrived at the house that is, now reconsidering, no longer his, Jeremy darted inside and secured the lock. The villagers from the outside were racing down the path like a widespread of savage chipmunks, and he hid himself beneath his desk. Jeremy began to contemplate on his decisions. On what he needs to do in order to restore all matters back to how they were before.

And he fell into a desperate state, incredibly bewildered under these circumstances. His tears trickled down as he refrained himself from crying aloud. The mystery of the item was so bizarre and irrational that he couldn't put his mind in place. What was going on? Why were his friends condemned right in front of his face? What did they do?

But no more despairing, Jeremy thought. He had enough of being a loon incapable of doing anything on his own. And now that such an opportunity was happening, he had to at least act upon it. To do something. To defend himself. To struggle, and to seek for options available that could surmount this unhinged fantasy.

"I-I'm... not crazy..." Jeremy uttered, knees upright to his chest, and gazing at his trembling hands. His voice was cracked up; he thought that if he spoke any more, it'd shatter like thin glass.

"I-I'm not crazy!" This time, he enforced his own tone and inner belief, gripping his hands as if he had finally accomplished his greatest aspiration. Jeremy sternly analyzed the past events in order to make connections as to what occurred, and their relationship with the current present.

That's when he realized. The reason why he is inhabiting this similar-like parallel world, is because of the armillary. Jeremy couldn't reason in his mind that this place was his home—because truthfully, it wasn't. It was... another universe, another timeline, or another copy; hopefully anything that is not his original one. Because he was never going to appreciate whatever this one brought upon him. No— he'll pay with ingratitude if that's where it'll result in.

Before his lifesource and spirit was wholly warped, Jeremy had reflected the clarity of the eyeball to the moonlight, and both shone together like a meteor collision. If that was the prime site that caused him to get transferred to such an inadequate environment, Jeremy had to repeat the same tactic.

With this idea in mind, he turned his head to revise the windows of his living room. But he immediately retracted it when at least two people were peeping in through the glass, resembling brainless maniacs. His respiration grew a little unstable after that.

Jeremy equipped the armillary in his hand for another time, and gave it a serious look. This look of affirmation that, despite the many shameless moments he has experienced, he'd be doing a favor for himself now.

He stood up from underneath the desk, flashing out his whereabouts to the people outside. Jeremy lifted the armillary up to the heavens, presenting it as if it were an offering to the gods. And as expected, the trajectory of the light aligned with the sphere's core, manifesting a brilliant combustion. The villagers had stormed in the house by force, but it was too late as Jeremy had merged into the light.

"Danger...danger....," these words iterated inside the blinding chambers. Continuously, endlessly, until there was no more darkness but pure illumination.

Jeremy spawned right where he was left at, crashing his stomach against his desk. The papers swept oppositely in a slow landing. He groaned and dropped to the floor in exhaustion. It was like he traveled at the speed of light and lifted a thousand pounds concurrently, which would explain the wasted adrenaline that he was feeling.

But there was a hunch taunting him again, that this wasn't his actual world.

The skies were ablaze in the day's prominent setting. Such a day for such a cloud-derived ambience. Jeremy's preoccupations did not fade the slightest as this landscape had. He investigated his house and found no person in sight. So, instead, he advanced to the knob of his door.

Opening it, he encountered a chaotic mess before his village. The people were attacking each other like combat scout members. Fire, there was excessive fire causing the corruption of homes and nature. Jeremy backed away in fear at first, but then rapidly tiptoed to the other side of the path to align the armillary with the sun. But there was no reaction. There was no celestial manifestation like before. The reflection... There was just... absolutely nothing.

And so Jeremy lowered his hand, feeling much like an idiot at this attempt. Had he been delusional all along? Then, was it just a dream?— No, but it couldn't be. After those experiences, Jeremy was certain for the first time in his life that everything occurred successively. That they were, in fact, real in some way.

"It's the moon," he spoke out loud. "The moon is the trigger." But his conclusion was abruptly interrupted by a mass of fighters.

Jeremy clumsily tripped to the other side of the pathway into his house. He hastily, then, heard someone from the window before his desk. Because of this, his instinct was to harbor the artifact in his belt bag.

“Jeremy?” Colin said in surprise, hunched beneath the frame. “Jeremy! You’re here!” He landed on the floor to jog towards Jeremy, but this one took a few steps back.

“W-wait! Wait! You’re Colin Stevato, right?” Jeremy blurted in preoccupation, raising his hands in defense. Colin stopped his walk and nodded, hesitant and confused. “No... but- agh... What day is it?”

“The 23rd... You went missing yesterday, Jeremy, during the Christmas event.” Jeremy surrendered his defensive mode in relief, sighing at this information. Colin frowned, though, and deliberately wondered.

“Why? What happened? Where did you hide?” The younger couldn’t even begin to recite everything, so he didn’t.

“Where are the rest?” Instead, he respectfully adjourned the question.

“We’ve all gathered on the second floor, packing up provisions to...survive... that.” Jeremy glanced behind at where Colin referred to. If it weren’t for the windows, the people would have already trampled inside the interior home. He looked back at him.

“What in the world is going on outside?”

Colin gave one of the most helpless stares, one that he himself would never muster to show in front of his friends. Considering that revealing his weaknesses to others was his major weakness, Colin, at that point, didn’t have the words to express the distress that was tormenting him.

“We don’t know.”

Colin and Jeremy returned to what they, at the moment, considered as their fort base. The group of friends were gathered together near the corners of the room, afraid, impatient. Alvina’s

triplet sisters knelt down on the floorboard, embracing each other dearly. Their faces perked up at the arrival of their friend Jeremy.

“Hah! You didn’t abandon us, after all!” Alvina suddenly leapt on him, the crash spooking him.

He was held back by his words when he remembered the awful scenes he had witnessed. He just had to tell his friends; it was an order. That alternate world that he mistakenly interfered with, he was sure it had to be whatever the future had in store for them. It was simply devastating, tragic. It was an occurrence he couldn’t begin to recall, but had to entail nevertheless.

“Jeremy...” Ennard dictated behind the people set on a row, alongside with Niche. Jeremy received goosebumps across his body when, after listening to his best friend and childhood friend’s voice, he visualized them getting condemned again. A sorrowful cry bursted from his breath, originating from that heartbroken chest.

Alvina softly removed her arms around Jeremy and examined that hysteric expression of anguish on Jeremy.

Before anyone spoke, he whimpered, “I saw you two die. Alvy and Ennard. You two died in the future.”

Everyone's mouths were clamped up by this statement, a terrific chill recurring them. Alvina and Ennard maintained a bewildered frown, speechless.

“Alvy dies?” One of the sisters repeated, their lips curling into a cry.

Alvina’s face twisted into a tempered one at the look of her sister. She then growled irritably, and grabbed Jeremy by the collar.

“What do you mean we die? Don’t go ahead and say these scary things in front of my sisters!”

“I’m being serious. I-” Jeremy paused for a second and delved his hand in his belt bag, retaining the armillary. He demonstrated the rusty-gilded sphere to his friends. “It’s this item! I shone it with the moonlight, and it transported me to another dimension. An alternate universe, or another world! I don’t know! I don’t even know myself! It was so... strange,” he quieted down, thinking to himself. The rest formed a grimace in a criticizing way, stupefied at what Jeremy said. Alvina released him.

“Sure, sure... so what happened? You just disappeared and woke up in another world?” Ennard mocked.

“That’s about it,” Jeremy confirmed. “I saw myself there. There was a march. It was *Pacific Deal* night, and the people were crowding up at the cliff. And you two, Alvy and Ennard, were kneeling down.”

They raised an eyebrow at each other, dubious-looking.

“And then what?” Niche said.

“And then... I was the one to push you two off. But it wasn’t me! It was another me! There were two versions of me, apparently, and in that world, I existed as well!”

The more Jeremy spoke, the more unbelievable the story was. They shared glances at each other as if they were concerned for his deteriorated mental health. But then Niche stepped forward, holding her single hand up as to make a public declaration.

“Guys,” she enforced. “I know that Jeremy is telling the truth. I’m the witness. I was there yesterday, in his room, when a white light shone at the corner of the door. And then when I

opened it, he was gone. No longer in his living room. That's why I searched for him in every house of Kamui Seigen. That's why I asked you, Colin and Ennard, if you had seen him."

"That doesn't mean Jeremy couldn't have staged it up. He could have used a lantern!"

Alvina commented.

"What good would Jeremy get out of that? What would even be his reason? Think about it logically: our island is not so big, and crossing The Other Side of the World would take days. Why would Jeremy do that?" That final sentence urged everyone to drop silent and listen diligently with their ears.

"Then where did you get that thing anyways?" Ennard asked, a tone of suspicion underlying his voice.

"My mom had it with her. It fell from her bag but she had walked down the stairs of the village already," Jeremy explained, wiping the tears that were shrinking little by little.

Colin proceeded to walk in front. He placed a kind hand on Jeremy's shoulder in assurance. "Well, now we know where Jeremy went, I guess. There's a lot of mysteries on this island, so it wouldn't surprise me if there are more to encounter. Now, we have to find a solution to what is happening outside with the people. Thank god our parents are hiding together safe."

Jeremy widened his eyes, anxious. He looked back at his friends in order.

"What's going on?"

Ennard spoke first.

"People are going crazy, that's what's going on," he retorted. "Last night, a person followed your little 'clumsy tradition', and burned the stage down again. Then they started to punch each other, and the whole building caught on fire."

Jeremy opened his mouth in shock. The others respectfully nodded to confirm his saying. The triplets cradled each other while inclining down, maintaining a strong and protective hold. This circumstance wouldn't be a foolish one that any jerk could be capable of doing. The entire village fears the power that the government possesses, so, indisputably, there must be something downright unfitting that is driving them this way. Why would the people be attacking each other if they are afraid of getting punished? It was easy: they weren't afraid.

"But why? When..." Jeremy trailed off. Colin retreated his hand.

"After you disappeared," Niche said.

There was a moment when Jeremy felt his hands abnormally heat up. He shot a look at the armillary and noticed that it was trembling in his hold, moving automatically. Everybody backed away in confusion against the walls. Jeremy dropped it to the floor, and the item discharged a thick smoke that whelmed the room. A tall, opulent woman appeared right before their eyes.

She was a purple-themed freak, looming with the color indigo and the rarest of aqua. Strands of her hair reached down to her hips, with a mighty crown fawning her notoriety. Her gown was a maiden one, spreading in either ways to extend her divine presence. A serpent roamed around her arm, while holding two ablaze torches upright. Her eyes were blank like the screen of oblivion, and despicable malice was her name.

The friends parted away from this creature, but Jeremy remained there, probably frozen from anxiety. It was as if it was meant to be. After all, he was, now, the possessor of such a godly item.

“Hello, Jeremy. I am the goddess Hecate, Jeremy. I’m the owner of the armillary as it was given to me as a gift by the gods,” she began to speak, and it sounded like an echoing enchantment.

“S-so t-this is yours!” Jeremy blurted rather rudely, holding out the armillary to her. But her face remained neutralized.

“No, it’s yours Jeremy. I did not want that since I am not fond of seeing the future, so I dropped it in your human world. After all, it would be quite interesting to see how things go havoc.”

Jeremy opened his mouth, somewhat offended. “You dropped this dangerous item here just because you didn’t want it? This is not our responsibility!”

“Now, now... I could bring an eternal moon if you respond to me with that attitude.” He flinched. “Jeremy, you’re on thin ice. And if you want my help, this’ll be a very compelling show for me,” the apparent goddess said with flattery, crossing her legs over an invisible seat, where she sat in mid-air.

“If what you’re saying is true...” Jeremy stated, thinking deeply. “Why did my mom have such a strange item with her anyway?”

Hecate grinned. “She, too, had used the power. She’s the second person who’s firstly held onto it, since your father was the first.”

“What... why?” Jeremy continued, dumbstruck.

“Your father used it to escape the island to the other side of the world. That is why your mother had it.”

“Wait, but if this is true... then shouldn’t the chaos that’s happening now have occurred back then?” Jeremy questioned.

“No, Jeremy. That was your mistake. You allowed your second version to see you, and that twisted the boundaries of reality and alternates. Distorted the laws of science. You’ve disturbed the gods because you, a mere mortal, have interfered with the consciousness of the future.”

“Hey, but that wasn’t- this was your doing! You made me grab the item, and unintentionally trigger it! How would’ve I known?!”

Hecate chuckles to herself, bothered that she did not have the ability nor power to silence the boy’s stubborn mouth. But she looked up again, and only said the simplest things.

“Disasters are going to be brought upon your village. He, who goes by Poseidon, is the same wielder who has made a pact with you, humans. Through the Vigilant Telescope, his eye will navigate and search for your findings, and make sure you are wounded. But watch out. If the world is not fixed, time will pass thrice as fast the more you use the artillery. And if you don’t deal with the other world, your island would explode, or your other self would come to kill you instead. You need to seize the second armillary to convert it into a divine weapon. Do that, and I’ll appear again.”

Without mercy, Hecate flashed before their eyes with this impending warning. Jeremy was absolutely aghast, and trembled at these words. There were more questions incited after her departure. More questions that, considering the conditions, he lost the chance to ask.

Jeremy gritted beneath his breath, fists clenched, “She... she thinks we’re just some puppets to play with.” He glanced up at his friends, at their apprehensive faces, and held a pitiful expression.

Everything had been all right the day before. Smiles. Conversations. The same old average days that, slowly as time ticked, were straying away from the custom. All because of a

divinity's own greed and entertainment. Jeremy didn't understand these irrationalities. Why is this all real? Why, out of everyone, had his father picked up that armillary? Was he that desperate to escape the family bond he had with Jeremy and his mother? Was he that disheartened he didn't care even the slightest bit about the consequences? Jeremy didn't want to understand.

The ground began to shake. An earthquake was happening; quivering the walls, the furniture, the tools on board. Alvina and her sisters grappled onto one another, as she protected them with her laced arms. Colin remained there as well to support the children. Ennard and Niche, however, made their way to Jeremy, who had turned his back to widely inspect the outside world.

A universal-sized eye was over the line of the clouds, roaming their lens in a frightening way. It was a god's, of course, because, last time they checked, nobody had the size of their eyeball as big as to engulf the skies.

"What is that...?" Ennard muttered, shocked.

"That's an eye, Ennard. And just like that person said, they're going to kill Jeremy," Niche explained.

Jeremy switched to her, frantically distraught. "Niche... just why? How is this real? If only I didn't pick up that armillary. No... if only my father didn't grab it... We wouldn't be in this situation... Only these things happen in comics, in books." And he looked at Ennard, who couldn't bear to give him a sight. As he remembered the times when they read fictional stories together, and they fantasized about converting it into reality.

"Jeremy, get your act together. Did you hear what she said? You need to return and fix the world," Niche commanded, startling Jeremy.

He sighed and closed his eyes, the earthquake recurring erratically to falter their stances. “I know, Niche. I know. But there is so much to take in. If my mom had that armillary with her, that means that one of the reasons why she volunteered in the expedition was to find my dad, isn’t it?”

Niche nodded, and stepped in. “And if you saw Alvina and Ennard die...”

“What about us?!” Alvina shouted from behind. Jeremy shared a stare with Niche together, growing more surprised in this realization.

“The future...” he mumbled. Everybody paused to listen to him. “The change in the future started the moment I grabbed the armillary.”

“Hey, what are you on about now?” Ennard snapped in front. Jeremy disregarded that and strolled to collect the item again.

The other world, the alternate world, was a universe where I hadn’t picked up the armillary, Jeremy thought. And it made sense. Because, as far as he remembered, Alvina and Ennard had the same clothes during *Pacific Deal* night. That meant that years had not passed, and that it was merely similar to his date.

After a long observation, Jeremy swapped to everyone’s attention.

“The moment I picked up the armillary was when the world had divided into two. Like ripping two pieces of paper. Now, you have two existences. The only way to solve this is to merge the universes. After all, this means that picking up the armillary was a mistake since it came from something as unpredictable as guts. Guts can’t be measured.”

Not a single sound was uttered. The group of people conceived this idea, and decided to believe it.

Colin stood up from his kneeling position. “But Jeremy, what are you implying? Didn’t the projection say you needed a weapon? That you needed the other armillary from the second world?”

“Exactly!” Jeremy exclaimed, content that he has, at once, found connections in the most stressful situation. “In order to merge this world, I need the other armillary and combine them or destroy them. That way it’s equal! I don’t know about the weapon, though. And if my guess is correct, that means that the armillary was picked up by someone else in the village!”

“That is a relief,” Niche admitted, placing her hand on Jeremy’s back. “Now, we should find a way out of here before the eye sees us, and help Jeremy shift to the second world.”

Jeremy smiled in early triumph, firmly staring at his friends. “And I know where to go.”

Long after the talk was finalized, the crowd gingerly maneuvered to the ladders and inside the home. Then they scurried to the other side of the alleyways, the pathways, into other corners where they could avoid the chaotic battles. Another disturbance was the earthquake but, compared to human influences, it wasn’t as challenging. They reached the peak of a tower, though they remained inside. Luckily, there was a round window frame imitating one of a medieval castle. This was beneficial for Jeremy when he would reflect the eye with the moonlight.

“I still find this stupid,” Alvina mentioned, holding her sisters by the hand.

Jeremy stretched his lips and dismissed it. He knew to himself that it was such an unrealistic scenario, but was, nevertheless, real.

“Jeremy needs a companion. If he goes all by himself, he’s gonna get killed by the people from the other world,” Niche informed.

“I can go but... I’m not suited to fight...” Colin trailed off, ashamed.

Pondering over this option, Jeremy came to the conclusion that he, instead, needed to be accompanied by people who were punished at the hole.

“Why?” Niche asked.

“Because it lowers the risk of you guys’ other self seeing you. When the other Jeremy saw me, I experienced a strong headache. Who knows if this also raises the chance of damaging the world any more?”

They nodded in agreement. There was nothing to refute, not that it would help at all or make a difference. The evening was blooming in the sunset, in contrast to the barbarian screams and the protruding eye. It was nearing. Time was nearing. And soon Jeremy would make his choice.

“Ennard and Alvina, I need you two,” Jeremy came up to them. They both frowned upon this order.

“What do you mean you need us? This is just some stupid fantasy!” Alvina retorted, arms crossed.

Ennard responded back at this delusion. “Are you kidding? After seeing that massive eye above us, you still think his story is less believable?” Then he switched to Jeremy, similarly bothered. “Do you even know if that thing could transport another person? Not one but two?!”

Jeremy recoiled back in steps; so much noise and scandal making him anxious. “I-I know it’s completely unreal but... we have to try, no?”

Ennard noticeably attempted to calm down, analyzing the situation a bit more prudently. He sighed, “the witch said that the more we went to the other world, the faster time would pass here. Same goes to how long we stay there, right?”

“That just means that the time zones will change, no? Just like it happened to me. When I transported, it was night time, and when I returned, it was daytime.”

“But what if years go by?” This dropped a silence.

Alvina and Jeremy glanced at each other. Jeremy prepared to give a generic solution in his mind.

“Then we have to make every second count. We can’t bear to lose a single one.”

The provisions were set at the corner of the dormer. In the tower, it was remodeled to suit the group’s survival basic necessities. Not for a long time, but long enough to prevent a global catastrophe. Alvina kissed her sisters on their cheeks, and waved with tears trickling down her face. Colin and Niche remained there in order to supervise them. Ennard gestured his own tempered form of saying goodbye, but he was, too, hurting.

Jeremy, Alvina, and Ennard convened at the highest frame of the tower, but not outside. The eye was still lingering, and they couldn’t bear to take such a risk.

“Wouldn’t we need weapons?” Ennard interrupted before the preliminary step.

Jeremy affirmed, “if there’s anything we need, we could always obtain them there.”

Before Jeremy raised the armillary to the moonlight that seeped through, his heart ached at the memory. *This is to save them. This is to save the present*, is what he repeated to himself.

Alvina and Ennard. The reason and judgment for their deaths was a mystery he had to solve complementarity. There was no way he would stitch up distinctive realities without understanding why such a minor change in his choices ended up in his friend’s death. Why his other self, if he could even refer to them as himself, would wear a callous mask.

His dearest friends, and he couldn’t bear a lifetime living without them.

The three friends each placed their palms beneath the item, sensing it mutually. Once the trace of the light clashed against the gilded orb, a luminous spark blinded them.

In an instant, they disappeared just like Jeremy did to the other side.

Chapter 3

Like a brisk windforce, they stumbled over their own feet and smacked their heads against the stonewall. A heavy pant occupied the air's breeze, as the friends were absolutely startled by this strange phenomenon. The journey and the transportation. It was like they were absorbed into a void and felt their hearts abandon their body for a brief moment. Jeremy, unlike the rest, perched up with little difficulty. Alvina and Ennard, however, were still aghast in such a perplexing manner.

"Guess it worked," Jeremy glanced at Ennard. He only gave him a breathless stare.

They soon marched down the stairs after recovering. There wasn't much time to lose and, it's not like they had the luxury to enjoy this abnormal trip. The sky, yet again, was sealed by a coal band, employing all sorts of splendid stars. Jeremy was unsure whether it was around the same period, or another day had passed already. All he knew was that, compared to last time he visited the area, the intensity of tonight's silence was fatal.

Assuring that nobody was in sight, they hurried to another alleyway, where darkness would entail. The group was following Jeremy without a clue of what their plan was.

"This is literally how our normal home looks like," Alvina mentioned, gazing at the steady tranquility.

"It is not," Jeremy stated, peeking at the pathways. "Everybody must be dunked asleep."

"Okay then, what's the plan? Not only did we come here without any protection, but you didn't prepare a single thing, did you?" Ennard snapped eagerly.

Jeremy sighed. "I want to see this place as if it is our normal village, that way it wouldn't be as hard to capture the artillery."

“That doesn’t answer my question!” The other countered back.

“We’re going to infiltrate the government’s house. We need to do that and first know what the expedition was about. We need to know who is the holder of the item.”

“And get us killed the moment we sneak in. That’s it? Just infiltrate it?” Ennard responded, obviously opposing this unreviewed preparation.

“No,” Jeremy grinned. “We will continue our traditions.”

Alvina gathered the two in a circle, producing sparks with her flint and steel skill. They were performing this with a chunk of ash wood collected next to the grass, like a giving. Ennard hummed in doubt.

“That won’t be enough. Hey Jeremy, how is it that you burnt the stage?” Ennard shot a smug at him.

He just grumbled, but nothing to serve his attitude. “It wasn’t intentional! I accidentally used a match!”

Alvina lit up like a cheered up puppy at her brilliant discovery. While she was ashamed, she was thankful for this conversation.

She delved in her pockets in a clumsy way, and located her product of interest.

“I forgot I had this!” she said, demonstrating the box of matches in her hand. Ennard didn’t dare to share his gratitude, since he was struck by disbelief that Alvina didn’t remember such a vital possession.

“Alvy,” Jeremy suddenly notified. They looked at him. “When you traded with the man, last time, you said that you were going to measure the depth of the hole. Weren’t you?”

She smiled, content at the prevail. “Oh, that! Yes, Ennard and I measured it, and it exceeded the measurement length! That hole is absolutely deep! There’s no way we’d be able to rappel down until reaching the surface!”

Jeremy was a little unsettled by this fact. He was, after all, suspicious of the reason why Alvina and Ennard were condemned. Why would they? Because of that trivial act? There is no way it could be because of such a minor incident! The only way to find out, according to him, was through other citizens in this village. Which would be almost impossible to do.

“Alright,” Jeremy affirmed, confidence instilling in him. “Let’s burn this place.”

And just like that, Alvina was given the privilege to rub the shaft of the matches altogether, converting them into an ignited torch. She hailed it up in excitement, while the two friends hid behind a shrub. They simply gave thumbs up just to not encourage her spirit negatively.

Alvina yanked the torch to the stage, the fire beginning to expand like roots, and the sizzling emitting upward into a steam.

She reverted without a halt, accompanying the two who strolled to the border of the island. The reek of crippling smoke was so fierce that they could even smell it from a mile away.

Because of this, the people desperately snapped their doors open and investigated this hazardous spectacle.

“Fire! Fire!” They all screamed.

The friends were proud of this, but Jeremy didn’t hold the same remark. He was still unsure as to what to do next.

“So, what’s next?” Alvina questioned like a bullet.

Jeremy breathed in erratically. Their first step succeeded, though he himself didn't feel like they would be able to accomplish anything any further. Was the fire a trigger?

"I-I don't know." But he did know. He wanted to know the truth of this world and the situations that had occurred the last two days. It was a fragment that could be used as a solution. "I don't know how we will be able to find the holder! I don't think we'll be able to do this!"

"Hey! Hey! But you were so confident minutes ago! When you plotted the dots! When you've realized so many details in little time, under pressure! What do you mean you can't do it? Do you even know what you're capable of?" Ennard repelled that tone of pessimism, wildly staring back. Jeremy was stunned, and so he pondered deeply for other alternatives.

Revising all the houses was an unrealistic idea. It would take a lot of time and, moreover, the villagers wouldn't allow that for too long. In order to find the artillery, he needed an opening, he needed an opportunity.

"Remember your dream, Jeremy. Remember that you have a life. I don't care what you say, you're not useless," Ennard continued. Alvina nodded.

Jeremy received memories. About his dream of becoming a sailor, of his dedication to construct a boat alongside Ennard in hopes that, one day, his village would be engulfed by oceanic water. Some day, there wouldn't be a government prohibiting their freedom, controlling their actions, and unfairly sentencing people. That he could travel, that he could learn what it is like to bathe in the sun and next to the bay. It was a combination of both hatred and aspiration. And that was a powerful duo.

"Alright," he sighed out, deciding on a strategy. "I got something in mind."

At the eastside of the island, the government's house lies there. At the west side, Jeremy's house lies. And at the northside, is where the rest of the houses are settled in, including the

direction to the hole. The main site the group was going to head to was Jeremy's house and the government's.

He planned this set-up. So, Ennard and Alvina teamed up to find the description and specifications of the expedition in the government's house. He had his full trust in them. And then, when they managed to do so, they would convene again at the tower. That way they had eagle eyesight and acknowledged where each other were. Jeremy was going by himself. It took a little coaxing, but managed to settle it straight.

"Be careful," both of them warned Jeremy. He nodded, and soon they diverted paths.

On the exterior, his alternate house seemed vacant. But somewhere in him knew to full extent that his other self rested there, inside, and somewhat waiting firmly.

Jeremy switched to The Center, where the majority of the commotion was situated. He was glad that this worked, at least, and that luckily the streets weren't so overpopulated. So, in a circumspect manner, he twisted the knob and met with the interior home.

It was a silent rendezvous. Jeremy inspected the corners, as there wasn't anything to check since his house was rather miniature. His heart accelerated and sweat formed in his tensed skin. He had to figure out how he was going to capture him and swap their identities.

Tiptoeing, Jeremy reached the other side of his door. He was anxious. His hand trembled at just simply raising it, but soon he mustered the courage to open it.

And before his room, he saw nothing prudent. No one.

Behind his back, someone was ready to throw their punch.

But Jeremy neutralized this attack, as he instantly slammed the door to their face. He remembered the disadvantage between doubles and therefore avoided eye contact. He panicked,

but this feeling did not induce him to surrender like always. Induce him to cower away. No, this time, he was sealing this.

“I have many questions for you, Jeremiah!” The first Jeremy declared, covering his line of vision with a palm.

The other rubbed their assailed nose, and they avoided eye contact as well, as if the sun’s beam was shining right at them. Then they charged at Jeremy like a bull, so he dodged this by swiping to the opposite side, where his creations were missing. He examined this bedroom, and realized that most of the changes were about his devotions. Knowing that there was almost nothing to throw back at the adversary, he grew infuriated.

“What happened to your boat, Jeremiah? To your ideas? To your dreams? Why did you change so much in less than a few hours?”

There was only a grunt out of vexation. “So, Jeremiah from the past. You’re here to kill me?” He said, standing up. “Do you want to replace me in this world instead?”

Jeremiah frowned upon this. “What? I’m not going to kill you! I’m not back here for that! Didn’t Hecate tell you?”

“Hecate?” Jeremiah said, lost. The other Jeremy understood that he wasn’t informed of any of this.

“But Jeremiah,” he asked nevertheless, still facing the floorboards. “What happened? Why did this world turn out like this?”

Jeremiah remained quiet, for a while. “Why were Alvina and Ennard condemned? I’m sure that if I were you, I would be equally as upset.” He said so, mercilessly.

“Then tell me everything that happened starting from... from when Niche was with you here. Here in our bedroom.”

Jeremiah raised an eyebrow. “Niche wasn’t with me here... she just left after Alvina got her goods and we climbed over the rooftops.”

“Well, exactly. What happened after that?”

They sighed, guilt projected in their face. “Alvina and Ennard killed our friends.”

Jeremy was in disbelief, shock, and in all stages of denial. What did he just hear?

“Right after Niche left,” they commenced their anecdote. “I heard that she went to The Center and reunited with Colin and Ennard. That’s when Alvina appears and tells them about her investigation. She asks for everyone to accompany her, not just Ennard. So everyone goes too because they’re curious about the hole. And what do you know? They went missing the next minute...”

“But it was an accident, wasn’t it?” Jeremy reassured himself, wonderbly.

Jeremiah denied that simplicity, a bothered voice reigning over. “No... you don’t know anything. The moment I heard the news, I just couldn’t tolerate it anymore. After losing my father, losing my mother, and then losing my friends... it was about time I gave up.”

Jeremy backed away at this, his hands quivering in place. This double, this other self, wasn’t him. Yes, he would consider himself, to some extent, the embodiment of misery and hopelessness, but this example was too outrageous. He despised visualizing himself being so self-destructive, so ruthless, so... insensitive.

“You’re not me. I wouldn’t give up on my friends so easily... I wouldn’t be so passive about them getting punished. Just how could you assume we were the same?” Jeremy contradicted. The other shared a sight that resembled his father, as both individuals equipped that similar level of heartlessness and relentlessness.

An arising noise from far ahead slowly emerged. Jeremiah marched away, prodding his shoulder against Jeremy's. Jeremy finally could observe his back as they weren't laced up in their eyes and that paranoia of receiving another headache. Given this distraction, he tackled the double from behind with a handkerchief from the bedroom. And then, through an impulse, he did not hesitate to smack Jeremiah's head with the artillery. The double lost consciousness and this caused a sense of triumph in him. It didn't go as exactly as planned because the initial plan was to capture him and confine him somewhere, but it ended up a little more violent. Jeremy feared critically injuring someone, especially himself.

With this done, and relieved that it didn't require much might, he transported the body to the bathroom. This way, he would be able to impersonate himself and replace each other's identities. With a small modification with his hair and facial expression, Jeremy was confident to go.

Ennard and Alvina hid behind the cabinet of the governor, where they lingered meticulously. They had to be careful of their surroundings, considering how they were storming in their property. Ennard glanced once more and realized that there was no one in sight, so he gestured to Alvina to stand up. He was obstinate in his decision since the governor had probably already garnered at The Center.

"You sure? What if Terry comes back?" She asked as Ennard advanced to the desk that appeared to be cluttered with paperload. Ennard wordlessly nodded.

"Wouldn't the expedition just be to collect provisions? Why does Jeremy doubt the government?" Ennard mumbled in a low volume, investigating the illegible handwriting.

“Shucks, I don’t know how to read, but I found something!” Alvina said, presenting a world map. Ennard widened his eyes in surprise, and rudely snatched the paper. He diligently scrutinized this valuable piece and came to a conclusion.

“Alvina,” he mentioned while being amazed, “The Other Side of the World is not that far away from here.”

“Oh,” she said, inspecting the graphic lands. “And why’s this circled?” She pointed at the westside, where the majority of the terrestrial surface was. But the dark-tinted circle was located at the top, encompassing a city.

“Was this where the ‘Scout of the Edge’ embarked?” Ennard wondered, but he only grew more confused and unsure. His attention switched back to the stacked papers and decided to search for something else in specific.

As Ennard did this, Alvina acquired the map for herself. He was remembering a statement that the goddess had mentioned. *“He, who goes by Poseidon, is the same wielder who has made a pact with you, humans.”* Ennard just couldn’t let go of that thought, like a steady anchor, until receiving the goods. The truth. As they were assigned by Jeremy to assemble the pieces, he couldn’t come out with his pockets empty. He was going to provide the best evidence and explanations.

And it was like luck. Thanks to his ability to read, he found the most compelling source.

It was a chronicle of the governor, apparently. It provided a successive summary and description of the historic events throughout the years. Ennard read it thoroughly, as it resembled what most villagers called a personal diary. In it, it said the following:

“As of today, September 27, 1918, the island of Kamui Seigen will desert its body of water to the God Poseidon, in exchange for absolute authority and governmental power over

anyone born upon those following years, in that island. The ruler, Joseph Markwand, swears to maintain the limitations of human capabilities, and that no other entity defies the prowess of divinity. In order to hinder any defiance, the Lord of Land will gouge a hole in case of any rebellion in demand to be judged. This treaty applies to the preceding generations and posterity under the influence of the government.”

This dumbstruck Ennard even more, and urged the interrogation of Sarah’s position. What did this pact mean? Regardless, he comprehended that there were no righteous intentions sworn, unlike this compromise. How did the government manage to communicate with the gods?

“Sarah’s father bid a compromise with the gods to keep us locked in here?” Ennard spoke out loud, a tone so harsh because of the impression.

Alvina frowned, exclaiming. “What are you talking about?!”

Ennard solely maintained his dull expression as to battle the discordance, demonstrating the annotation. “This. I’m talking about this! The world changed years ago because Joseph Markwand wanted to keep us here! To control us! Remember what that witch said? That a certain human made a pact with the other god whatever-his-name-is? This... this looks like it’s a transcript, or the original document.”

Alvina couldn’t manage to process anything through, regardless of what Ennard conveyed, and so she ripped the paper out of his hands. She squinted at the words, trying to separate them from each other, and distinguish them individually. “Joseph Markwand... Lord of the Land... water... hole...,” those were the exact excerpts that determined her decision and trust. So, after all these years of restriction and objection, the government’s sole goal was power and authority. She did not falter her expression since, as spontaneous and eccentric as it sounds, this was the solution to every scientist’s predicament. Every scientist that has lived off the island

has exerted themselves to the extreme, all for a mere mythological rationale. Instead, she was more disappointed than surprised.

“We should’ve expected this. How is it possible to live on an island without the ocean, when we spend our lives reading books and illustrations showing a big land covered by water? It wouldn’t have made sense. Remember the measurement we recorded from the hole? That is inhumanely impossible for any person to have done that with their bare hands.”

As Ennard meekly paid attention to her elaboration, which was a rare one, he simply assented. Alvina spoke once more.

“Let’s show this to Jeremy. Hopefully we’ll be able to find the other armillary with this information.”

Ennard was dubious about that statement, about the limitations of the document, but still complied. He wanted to get out of that universe as fast as possible; it was like he was living in an unaffiliated lucid dream, but not a pleasant one.

Through all chaos, Jeremy came across a wild encounter with Alexander, harboring a glinted item in his hands, beneath his shoulders. The secretive pose was a suspicious one, and it inevitably urged Jeremy to follow his tracks. He was, after all, wearing an olive-coloured coat like a granny and warily trailed down the pathway to The Center. The fire was still proliferating throughout the weakest spots of the wooden stage. Jeremy tailed his track and then suddenly Alexander made a swift turn to the side. He halted, glancing at the alleyway in a circumspect manner.

Jeremy thought to himself, and wondered if he already noticed someone following him. He proceeded with careful steps, and slowly reached the end of this veiled passage. And oddly enough, this time he detected a hasty figure crossing the streets. It was so conspicuous that,

because of the reflection of the moon, its silhouette encouraged Jeremy to advance to another corner. At that moment, he was able to come to a face-to-face encounter with this mysterious escapee.

Cornered within the alleyway, Jeremy solely measured the person's back in every possible way. And before he could infer, someone had rapidly dropped from the roof, towards him. Jeremy limped before this ambush, and realized that it was Alexander, after all, who had maneuvered him into this trap.

"Alexander... you've-!" Jeremy exclaimed, breathless. He perched up without a second to waste, but was, nevertheless, cornered by his two other friends. Terry and Timothy lingered at the scene, blocking the exits.

"You're not the Jeremiah we know, aren't you?" He stated, demonstrating the celestial armillary sphere on his hand, proximate to his waist. The hood and cape slightly concealed his appearance, as he maintained one of the most devoted faces Jeremy had ever seen from him.

"Both of us aren't good pals... right?" Jeremy questioned, diverting from the primary topic. He glared at the treasure Alexander had in hand. A great feeling of elation relaxed his muscles, but Jeremy knew that this discourse had not finished yet.

Alexander lowered down his hood. "Searching for this, too, huh?" He said with a jeerful tone, displaying the item to Jeremy like some cheers. "I'm sure the goddess Hecate has explained it to you, just like me, about what's going on. It didn't even take an effort to figure out who it was. Why else would you be following me, impostor?"

Out of everyone, Jeremy inquired why the tenacious Alexander had to be the one to behold such power. Why did he obtain the privilege of a priceless item? He considered it quite inconvenient that he had to deal with the least friendliest group of people for this kind of ordeal.

But nevermind that, he had to fathom a way to circumvent this unavoidable situation. Lie? He was unsure as to disregard his dignity, but this was not his world, though.

“What do you mean impostor? I’m just as confused! I want to know why I’m somewhere where I’m not supposed to be!” Jeremy reasoned, undecided whether to pursue this falsity. He was using all his pawns in one go; everything to protect the armillary stored in his waist bag.

Alexander did not pay attention to that, and narrowed his eyes.

“I don’t know what you’re getting out of this,” he simply mocked and switched to those behind Jeremy with an implicit gesture.

Jeremy panicked and glanced at the directed side, which commanded Alexander to charge at his back. “But your armillary is surely hiding in your pockets!”

To an extent, Jeremy tripped, but he managed to stand up, glide against the surface and fetch for the second armillary. But he was slower-paced than the rest. Alexander made sure to fling the sphere frontward, making Terry pull up and secure it. Jeremy gasped at this and frustration clouded his mindset, that he mindlessly sprinted towards the holder.

Timothy assured to impede him from passing his barricading arms, so Jeremy did not falter. He unfastened his waist bag and yanked it to the hanging pole with a flag, clipping it. Then, he leaped and pulled, ascending to the thin stand, where he had to decide whether to climb the roof or collapse.

But once Jeremy retrieved his bag, his armillary slipped out of its spot and made its fall. Jeremy shouted in desperation, maintaining balance on the pole. Timothy was at the verge of catching it until Jeremy landed back again on the ground. This motioned Timothy to lose a grip on the sphere and indeliberately tumbled over.

It began to roll outside of the alleyway, urging every single one of them to come forth like tempered ants.

Alexander dashed towards it like the wind's tides, and removed his cloak to obscure the item from the moonlight. Jeremy took a note of it, and realized that if Alexander was aware of such perks, he had used its power at least once. Had he been the one to put the stage on fire? Just like he did?

Jeremy arrived and sought for the armillary without a polite care, but was subdued by Timothy's impactful punch. He landed on the floor, deliberated by a hazy mind. If it weren't for his stamina and weakness... it would not have turned out unsuccessful. Terry tossed the other version to Alexander and he obtained it on a whim. A wide smile out of triumph expanding.

"Finally," he muttered. "The divine sword! I'll finally be a winner!"

Alexander slowly uncovered Jeremy's affiliated armillary, letting the cloak rest on his forearm. And as he was about to unite them two, Alvina appeared out of nowhere with a memorable entrance. She kicked Alexander's face by the side, launching his stature down. She then maintained uplift and snatched the cloak on a whim, releasing a laugh.

"I'll take this, please and thank you!" She wore it around her neck as if it was her property. While regaining stability, Jeremy discerned the wrapped piece of paper beneath her arm with a strong hold. Was that some kind of crucial information she had with her?

Everything was occurring swiftly and progressively. Because of Alvina's tackle, the two armillaries went flying and rolled over the ground. They eventually reached Ennard's shoes, before him. So Ennard gingerly arched his back and obtained these two spheres, mildly paying them a look.

“No... you’re supposed to be dead! What- why are you here?!” Terry spat out just before Alvina knocked him out by a lanky chop on the neck. Timothy was being stepped on by her, so he didn’t dare to move.

“He’s not the Ennard we know,” Alexander clarified in-between coughs.

Ennard dismissed this frivolous conversation and maintained a grip on the two, attempting to merge them. Alexander grew more anxious that someone was stealing his spotlight, but he rest assured the moment that no reaction happened. Everyone was a little struck.

But Ennard didn’t waste time and his mental capabilities. He, then confidently, lifted them to clash against the moonlight, causing the space in his hands to gleam. The majority of the area flashed an intense light around him as the moonlight converted them into its mystic manifestation. It was like an uproaring wind engulfing them all, as these events unfolded.

Though it didn’t even last a minute, it was surely enduring. Ennard and the rest detached themselves from this experience and all inexplicable chaos ceased. And instead of two customary spheres, he wielded a seer sword, which featured the eminent eye at the corner of its blade. It was twice as long as the distance between Ennard’s hands.

Alexander limped as he stood up, disbelief planted on his face. No, everyone was feeling that same kind of amusement of such a mighty item. But time was rushing. The people’s attention had been disrupted and therefore sparked. Many of them were wondrously targeting the source of unprecedented luminality.

“We need to leave!” Alvina advertised, becoming more and more impatient at this instigation. She cradled Jeremy’s worn state, arm around the crook of her neck and shoulders.

“What about the other Jeremy?!” Ennard opposed, careful with how they manage their options.

Jeremy thought deeply, but he scoffed. “We don’t need to worry about it. That Jeremiah is, after all, nothing compared to me,” he said from memory and the disappointed impression of him. He didn’t seem like he was a big deal, considering how he wasn’t truly Jeremy himself. But just another copy.

“Okay. Great! But how do we leave? You’ve turned that into a completely different object!” Alvina shouted.

Ennard disregarded her complaint as he already knew the solution in hand. He raised his hand and bellowed for Alvina’s. She complied as she understood that they were going to use the eye from the seer sword to reflect upon the sky.

The moment Ennard put this into practice Terry, however, charged at them, causing the four to get warped into the transference altogether.

Chapter 4

The group reappeared but, this time, the primary world was rather distorted. Distorted is how they would describe the climate and other uncontrollable conditions. There was rumbling, thundering and, moreover, water was seeping through the cracks of the dried surface land. The four of them crashed against the floor to realize that the riot that was occurring before, had been replaced with torrential natural disasters. They didn't even dare to ask as Ennard and Terry were fighting over the sword.

"Why are you being so petty?! Weren't you mad because we had intruded in your world, you hypocrite?" Ennard snarled while Terry gripped the handle steadily.

"And that is right! I want to get the hell out of this island! I want to make a promise, if only you'd give me what's mine!"

Ennard made a hop to kick Terry on the stomach. He was sent to the opposite direction, collapsing on the ground. The knife remained in his hands, and he switched to his friends.

Alvina had fled to revise her siblings. And Jeremy balanced himself in a serene mindset. The skies were clouded by the empowering darkness, and screams filled with fright traveled across the air. People screaming, people weeping. No matter how much knowledge and comprehension they had towards this situation, they could not bear to believe it was possible.

Finally, after years of youth, they get to experience their island being covered by water.

Jeremy couldn't linger there any longer. Yes, acquiring the seer sword was his utmost priority, but it didn't feel right just yet. He had to check on his people's welfare, he had to convene to his friends.

Hitherto, he ran away from the scene, leaving Ennard alone with the divine weapon.

“Guys, guys! Are you alright?” He asked with care in his eyes, crouching down before Colin and Niche, who were protecting the siblings. Alvina had been talking to them at their side, probably about everything that has occurred so far.

“Yes, we are. We were planning to move to another place, but the climate scared us. We couldn’t risk getting hurt in any way,” Colin explained. “In the meantime, we just told stories and fell asleep.”

“That’s good,” Jeremy immediately replied. He examined his friend’s distressed faces and acknowledged the fact that they had to know about the events.

“So, after we found this, Ennard and I exited the governor’s home and found the three jerks bothering Jeremy. And then, Alexander had the two armillaries! I was glad I was able to score that kick! If it weren’t for that, I wouldn’t have grabbed this amazing cloak!” Alvina entailed enthusiastically, presenting the souvenir she obtained.

Jeremy adjourned the story-telling, “Wait, let me read that.” Alvina did as said, handing him the documents. He skimmed through the message and pledge, learning about dirty lies that have been hiding in the island where he has forever lived on.

“Our island was cursed by the government,” he whispered. They frowned at him as if he was a maniac. He demonstrated it to them.

“So that’s laying in the governor’s house? The same version?” Colin asked. Alvina nodded. “And then what?”

He encouraged her to continue. “Then, Ennard did this crazy thing! He grabbed both armillaries, and then he raised them up as if he knew what he was doing! And they merged into a sword! He-” Alvina hysterically turned to Jeremy, and halted at the realization. “Wait... where’s Ennard?”

Jeremy harshly bit his lip. "I left him. I wanted to check on you all so I..." He stopped when he saw his friends' baffled expressions. "Hey! I know it was stupid but- I trust him! I know that he is capable of protecting himself! I was just... impatient!"

Alvina rolled her eyes and shoved that inequality away. "Well, anyway. Then he obtained that weird-looking sword, the one we were definitely looking for. And it seemed that Jeremy's other half was a jerk as well, no?"

She turned her head to confirm her sources, and Jeremy asserted.

"So, we decided to return since we caused all that chaos, but the other Terry came with us! But it's weird since we didn't see your other halves."

Jeremy imposed. "Jeremiah told me they were dead."

They were stunned by this, fully attentive to him.

"Jeremiah told me that the reason why Ennard and Alvina were punished was because they allegedly pushed both of you down the hole."

"We would never do that, though!" Alvina retorted.

"Well, that's what he said. I don't know if it's true. I'll never know if it's true. But what I do know is that that wasn't the real me. It was already a fact since the beginning because two versions of me can't think alike."

"Wait. So you're telling us this all happened within a few hours?" Niche asked.

They affirmed it.

"Three days have passed. The last time we went outside was to restock our provisions. How did time move so fast?" She informed me, lost at her own sentence. They didn't exactly have the answer, they just knew that whatever that was causing this, had no explanation.

Jeremy raised himself up. He abandoned the tower without another word and decided to relocate for Ennard. He, after all, had to put an end to this nightmare.

But when he visited the same area, Terry and Ennard were not there.

All he noticed was the white cat affiliated to this place, staring wildly at him. But then a combustion irked against the rain and fever.

Ennard and Terry had crashed on the ground implying that they were traveling through universes.

"Stop meddling when you're not involved in this!" He finalized the fight by slamming their elbow against Ennard's face. Lifting the sword up, it urged him to indirectly question.

"You're not the holder of the sword either," he seethed, wiping off his mouth.

"Alex's mistake was trusting me. I will exchange the armillary."

"Exchange?" Jeremy suddenly interrupted.

"Exchange the armillary to erase this world. You see, I am tired of so much betrayal among the people. So, after every single one of Jeremiah's friends died, I felt at ease. That meant I could now be included in the next expeditions, and that way I would abandon my own mother! You think living here is great?"

"What do you know about living great? You've never even got to feel what it's like to suffer. What it's like when people are against you! When your interests are rejected! Or do you, spoiled kid?" Ennard retorted, wobbling putting his feet in-place after Jeremy's attempt to support. He shooed him away with a hand.

"Well, I don't care what you think. I don't know you, after all. You're not the real Ennard," Terry shrugged with humor, caressing the keen blade. "Forget about the wish, I'm gonna kill you both." And he made his final statement before focusing on the sword.

A lightning struck the colossal tree, the electrical currents rooting down to the bottom. The ignited fire was immediately extinguished by the rain, but the stability of the tree was lesser now. It was split in half, as its branches gradually rotated to land over Terry.

Jeremy saw this frightening opportunity to knock Terry to the other side. He snatched the sword and was ready to escape until Terry detained his ankle and seized it instead. He pointed it at the moonlight for Ennard to instinctively hold onto him and they mutually transfer universes.

They were greeted by the special atmosphere. And then by the unfamiliar atmosphere. Again and again and again until he lost consciousness of the original one. Ennard could finally annul that nauseous motion and reappear in a brighten world. After so many trials, he was unsure whether this was the right one.

Firmly retrieving the sword, Ennard backed away. While keeping an eye on the impostor, he checked his surroundings.

“The sword doesn’t work now,” he uttered, distancing himself from Terry. Ennard scrutinized any meticulous detail of the place, and couldn’t fathom whether it was his. Then, he received the splendid idea of going to Jeremy’s house to confirm it.

He did, and he opened the door like usual, with a defensive stance. There was silence until Jeremy’s voice tunes in.

“Who is it?”

Ennard refrained from speaking out loud as his doubts were cleared. A black cat navigating down the entrance, and stepping across the sidewalk.

He slowly retreated and left the door ajar, carelessly, to advance to the streets in order to hide in the alley.

“Hecate... I need your damn help. Terry ruined everything for us. Let me return to my home,” he whispered to the sword, somewhat odd to picture.

Ennard effortlessly summoned Hecate with the biggest grin on her face, delicacy also ruling her disposition.

“My, my, this was much better than a birthday present!” She exclaimed. He already knew she had been watching every event from the top of her cloud.

“I need to return,” he stated.

“Oh, but you can’t just break the system. It’s daytime. Wait until the moon resurfaces.”

“No,” Ennard said. “Let me talk to the other gods. Let me talk to the God of the Sun.”

“You can’t just order me around. You’re a mere human.”

“Okay then, I’ll destroy the sword by putting it in the furnace. That way, your show will be over.”

“No! I mean, don’t do that!” Hecate pleaded.

Jeremy had entered the tower’s window with a new foodload in his hands. He kneeled down and distributed the sliced peaches and water amongst the crowd. Niche, Colin, Alvina, and her siblings. They were practically making their own base after a week and a half, considering the many people attempting to barrage in and the natural disasters recurring every second.

He stood up. They were silently grieving the days passed without Ennard’s presence, without his existence. Their friend had been brought upon the other world, and they were unsure if he was stuck, in grave danger, or was basically the end.

The most tumultuous thunder struck, inducing them to cover their heads and ears. Since Jeremy was the only one uplift, he noticed the unnatural electricity surrounding a human shadow.

“Colin!” Jeremy commanded him. He tied a rope around the hook of the interior, allowing Jeremy to grapple it and descend the tower from the outside like he had just done. And he dropped on the ground towards it.

The friends watched how he directed this phenomenon with no equipment or safety measures. As Jeremy neared in surprise, he began to realize that it was the one and only Ennard holding onto that enchanted sword. But there was something evidently different about it compared to last time.

The closer he got, the more questions he dared to bid after that extended absence.

In shock, Jeremy reached Ennard while that whelming light faded away from his ambience. Such as the flint in his eyes and the menacing in his hand. A white-bleached and modified buster sword.

It was like he regained his consciousness the moment his body returned to normal. Ennard flickered his eyes at his environment, groggy at how much he traveled within such a short period of time. He glanced up at Jeremy, sharing a quiet mindful connection.

“How much time has passed... ever since I left?” He delicately asked, guilt succumbing to his face.

“A week and a half.” A muffled thunder struck in the clouds, implying that it was going to heavily rain like before. Raindrops began to fall.

“I’m sorry,” Ennard then consulted, not averting his eyes. “I had to shorten my lifespan to get here faster. It was daytime and I couldn’t bear to waste another second. Time here passes thrice as fast as the times this power was used, right? I had to consider that, since we had overused it so many times, that it could have taken months... years...!”

Jeremy stared wide-eyed, breathless at the thought of being alienated from his friend.

“And you sacrificed your lifespan? Why...that?”

“If I’m going to be separated from all of you, I’d rather that it doesn’t take the entirety of my life away. Forty years is enough years to spend wisely,” said with a solemn expression, he examined Jeremy’s reaction and handed over the sword.

“This is the Golden Age sword. I’ll pass the power to you. It’s only fair.”

Jeremy grabbed the handle, a rough grip on it. There was something inexplicable about acquiring that item; like, yet again, the same feeling of fantasy, strength, and prosperity.

Hecate faded in between the two. Ennard’s face completely twisted into a bothered one, but he wasn’t going to talk about it.

“Poseidon and Cronus will be here shortly. Now, how will you muster the courage and the strength to defeat a god? Do you have what it takes?” She introduced with derision, evaporating in between the rain.

His friends were pacing up from behind, all of them to reunite. Jeremy turned away.

Ever since the start, he had been bothered by how this god had set up this predicament for her own entertainment. Bothered by how he had to worry about trivial matters. Bothered by how he had to endure the loss of his friend and the risk of losing his life. He had enough of it.

Poseidon, the god of the sea and earthquakes, and Cronus, the god of time, rose up as if it were from their tomb. Levitating in the sky in such an unbelievable distance he knew he wouldn’t reach. These two leaders stood side-by-side at a great height. Was he really ready and up to slaying them? There were gods, after all! Gods that maintained the land, the production, and the circuit of life.

He gazed at the skies, undoubtedly lost, and switched to Ennard. He shrugged with a smile on his face, hands indicating nothing in absolute. “Take the initiative, Jeremy.”

The god Poseidon surged the water from the land's cracks and surface areas, directing it to Jeremy. It was forming some sort of orb and molded personification of humans readying to attack. Then, the god Cronus stretched his hand out targeting a tree. Ennard looked up to notice that this tree's longevity was aging at an unprecedented rate, causing it to become dry and brittle. The tree fractured and tilted over, aiming to fall on Ennard. Ennard dodged and shouted out loud why this tree had such an unavoidable curse to itself.

"The kids!" Colin yelled, running towards the tower and lifting himself up by the rope. Alvina tailed him.

Niche held out her axe, anchored to her arm like always. She prepared her stance. "I'll cover you. Do what you have to do."

Jeremy maintained an even mightier grip on the sword, and charged forth. She followed with the equal velocity, chopping off the heads of these embodiments.

Judging by how Jeremy had not been transported despite the many reflections of the moonlight, his weapon only worked in broad daylight.

The closer he got, Jeremy deviated from his intended goal. Why was he aiming to kill off two gods? He just wanted to live normally again. With his friends. With his mother. To never know about the future. About the ways it can be divided.

He leaped from the rooftops and started floating for some reason.

A voice reverberated in his mind. *"Don't worry, I'm passing you the superability to float. With this, you'll have a closer hit."*

And he slowed down as he prepared the initial swing.

Jeremy knew what he wanted. It was true that he has always been portrayed as some useless and incompetent villager, in comparison to his mother. It was true that he sought for ways

to prove the people of his value, of his capabilities. He wanted to do every single little deed that would grant him a new label. A new “I’m this courageous to do it” label. But he was never acknowledged. Never.

Memories of his friends violently assaulted him. The enjoyable moments. The jolly time spent together, with his friends. He didn't have anyone else's approval, because in order to gain that, he needed to be approved by himself first.

He remained a stodgy look, lowering his sword down. “I want to talk to gods.”

Hecate groaned in irritation. “What? Again?!”

“I’m not going to overstep my boundaries,” Jeremy reasoned. Poseidon and Cronus appeared before him, on the rooftop. Niche was nearby.

“Gods like you would prioritize the sacred word of a human rather than a subordinate's, right?” Jeremy asked. They nodded in unison.

“How could you do this? Why? I gave you the divine weapon!” Hecate complained behind them.

“Why would I comply with my enemy? With the person who has fiddled with my life? Who has caused our best friend to shorten his lifespan for us?” Jeremy stated with firmness. “It was about time I stood for myself.”

“*Bid your offering,*” they resonated. Jeremy understood what this meant, considering how Ennard had experienced it already.

But he contemplated on his options; he wasn't quite sure what he wanted to propose.

“I... offer this weapon, which belongs to you, and the life of Hecate.”

“What?! No, this can't be! You can't be this haughty!-” Jeremy thrust the blade on her chest, the injury flashing like a celestial star. Her form drifted off until ceasing to exist.

She evaporated in thin air, and the war had terminated.

The thunder grew less tense, but the uncanny night sky remained the same. The gods also took their leave.

“Jeremy, look!” Niche detached Jeremy from his ponderings, as he faced Niche’s pointing direction. It was the gushing ocean originating from the cracks, and the hole was nowhere to be found.

“We are liberated,” he said to himself as if it were a dream. The rain joined the clouds.

“What is going on? Why is there so much water surrounding us?”

“Mom! We’re going to drown! Mom!”

A disparate trend of comments surged from the bundle. The people amassed before the Center, and the governor attempted to calm down its citizens by assuring that it could be due to the excessive rain and that it would be cleared up soon.

“How is that amount going to get dried up! Are you even hearing yourself?! These aren’t mere puddles!” One of them complained.

“I don’t see any way in which this poses a threat. Please calm down, we’ll evacuate to the tower, and I’ll hitch my bestest scientists to explain the perplexity of the situation!”

“I’m sure you’re aware of what is happening, Ms. Markwand,” Ennard dictated from the steep guardrail. The majority of the public eye concentrated on this unusual speech like fireflies.

She stepped in front, mildly vexed. “What do you mean by that, Grey?”

“I’m talking about your pacts, ma’am,” he mocked with a curve in his smile. Alvina handed him the rolled sheet.

Ennard presented it to the people, and the governor, needless to say, was aghast.

“As of today, September 27, 1918, the island of Kamui Seigen will desert-”

“No! No! Where in the world did you get that?!” Sarah interrupted, altered. She switched to her protectors. “Come on! Do something!”

“But this kid isn’t causing any harm to our people,” they rationalized.

“Nonsense! He’s violating the right to-”

“For freedom of speech?” Ennard finished the part.

“No! To be in accord with the governor, for trespassing my property!”

“I’ve never entered your property. I mean, it’s technically not yours, so I didn’t lay a finger on a single object. I have your son as testimony.”

Sarah cocked an eyebrow and turned to Terry.

He defended himself. “I have nothing to do with this! I don’t even know what this guy is talking about!”

“But have you ever seen me around her place, even four meters close?”

She glared at him as if her life depended on his answer, but since he was lost on track, Terry simply nodded in negation. She switched back to Ennard in disappointment and utter disbelief.

“See that? I’m right. Now, on the paper I have in hand, it states how dear Joseph Markwand pledged to the god Poseidon to eradicate the seas that nourished us and allowed transportation, in exchange for power. Yeah, you heard me right. And in exchange, he swore to restrict us, lodgers, by keeping us trapped here and punished by the hole. Now tell me, isn’t that unfair?”

“As if anyone would believe your story!” Sarah responded.

“Then you can ask Jeremy, you can ask Colin, you can ask Niche, Alvy, or her sisters about it! You can ask the literates, you can ask the scientists after years of no progress. Nothing

will ever explain it.” Ennard handed the document to a person in the herd, and they each began to pass it to one another. Meanwhile, he continued, “Tell me, where can we get our hands on a printing press? At the Other Side of the World, where we’ve been so obscured from! It is the only possible place to ink a paper. I’m even sure that none of you know what a printing press is!”

They began to perceive their dear governor differently. They were supposed to be the person to keep them safe when necessary, to avail them, support them in their decisions, but not judge them if they show opposition. They began to wonder if the people they have executed throughout the years were actually, indeed, innocent. Lost family members, lost lives...

“And I don’t care about the consequences. Trust me, I don’t care. The reason why we’re here is because Markwand decided to carry on the pact. She didn’t want to cancel it, she didn’t want to break it, in exchange for power. Sure, what a great way to sustain our community, but to preclude us from modernization? To live off as ignorant people? I don’t know about you all, but I wouldn’t want to live my life like that.”

“Now, it’s your decision to do whatever you want with this information. I, Ennard Grey, renounce my citizenship!” He cheekily declared, walking out from the center of attention.

Ennard and his friends convened at the border of the island, near Niche’s house. They gathered before the edge, and a colossal sailboat lodged in the water, secured by the tree. Colin had just finished forming a stable knot, and Jeremy planted the mast.

“That was fast,” Ennard commented.

“We hurried and fetched for the boat since we were worried that the people would follow us,” Niche explained.

“And you, Colin?” He directed him once he faced the group.

He steadily sighed, a gloomy appeal forming before his expression. “Well, I... My dad didn’t agree to this. I can’t go with you all,” he lamented. The rest acknowledged the weight that Colin was enduring, and they also knew how guilty he felt.

“Don’t you worry, Colin,” Alvina said behind them. They all turned to her to notice her eyes dampened with tears, and her lips holding in her withdrawn bawl. Her sisters remained still, in a cluster, locking on to each other’s hands. “We know how frustrated you feel, and you know how big of a dream this is for us.” Colin lightly nodded. “We will miss you, and we will not forget you.”

Said this, everyone was urged to hug the tallest member of the friend group, an endearing hug sealing the rupture between the five of them. That, despite this rift, they will always hold a special place in their hearts for Colin, their dear friend, and the memories forged in their homeland.

Jeremy was the last one to share the embrace, encouraged by Ennard’s beckoning hand. They lasted for a solid thirty seconds, and gave a final look to everything surrounding them. The land, the trees, the houses, the center, the bushes, the sky, the people, the presence, and the standing figure of Colin.

Alvina ushered her sisters to climb aboard on the platform, and they did. They managed to fit in diligently, preparing the coordinates, preparing the journey. And with another glimpse to their customary world, Colin detached the rope from the tree. They slid across the water as if they were about to fall. It was a newfound sensation for them, being in a floating state. And it was strange. Most of the time, they were convinced that they would, somehow, drop to the void of the universe.

But regardless of those preoccupations, nothing else happened. Ennard released the mainsail and the jib, bestowing a small boost. Jeremy maneuvered the wheel, pointing to the direction where the “Scout of the edge” embarked to.

The wind brushed their cheeks like peace and tranquility’s palm, guaranteeing solemnity and good resolutions in life. It was vivid and fantastic at the same time— magical, even. As if their souls opened themselves like wide doors, introducing this new chapter in life. After their entire lives being entrapped in a place where they could’ve just appointed as their origin but not their home, the felt betrayal ceased.

Jeremy is searching for his mother, Ennard is looking for a taste of modernization, Niche is looking for a challenge, and Alvina is wishing for a better life for her sisters. The future and the possibilities appear to be frightening to confront at first, but all it takes is an initial step.

Now, they anticipated the new bringings of this future, each protagonist thriving for a personal desire to achieve.

The End.